CreaTech Showcase 2026

WHERE CODE BECOMES CULTURE

Where a tool ends and a ritual begins...

Atsushi Yang

Every tool has a job.

A mug carries a moment of pause. A notebook holds what has passed and reaches toward what might come. A bow launches an arrow. But look closer at the moments surrounding these acts — the teabag hung just so on the rim, the first mark drawn before writing begins, the slow drawing of a bow before release — and something shifts, as **meaning settles into the gesture** and changes its weight. The object's nature hasn't changed. The function hasn't changed. Yet the action feels different: measured, repeated, charged with a meaning that exceeds mere use.

Where a Tool Ends and a Ritual Begins sits with that shift.

This work is the opening inquiry of a design research project exploring what makes certain everyday activities sustaining rather than simply useful. A ritual, as used here, is not a ceremony or religious act — it is a repeated, embodied action that a person loads with personal meaning, one that marks time, focuses attention, or quietly declares who they are. **Tools and rituals are not opposites.** They are neighbours, and the boundary between them is not fixed.

The objects on display are chosen to make that boundary visible. In each pair, near-identical gestures carry vastly different weights. One pair is casual and improvised. The other is deliberate and inherited. **Yet the ritual object** in each pair does something more than the tool beside it.

The question this exhibition sits with is a design question: if the same gesture can be tool-use or ritual depending on context and intention, what does that mean for **how we design the objects and systems** people live with every day?

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projects/where-a-tool-ends/